memorable remark. ‘Rajdeep, once the BJP crosses 220 seats, it will become a secular party for everyone!’

Prophetic words. Just a week before the big election announcement, Ram Vilas Paswan joined the NDA. It was a psychologically important moment. Paswan, after all, had left the NDA in 2002 over the Gujarat riots, demanding Modi’s resignation. Now, the Dalit leader from Bihar was sharing a stage with the man whom he once accused of ‘dividing’ the country.

The backstory to Paswan’s re-entry into the NDA fold is indicative of how the die was being cast. For months, Paswan had been trying to forge a grand ‘secular’ alliance in Bihar with Lalu Prasad and the Congress. Lalu wouldn’t take his calls, the Congress was undecided. Then, one evening, Paswan met Bihar BJP leader Shahnawaz Hussain on a flight. ‘Why don’t you consider joining the NDA—we may be able to give you a better deal,’ Hussain told him.

Paswan prevaricated at first but his son Chirag grabbed at the idea. The dashing young man had tried his hand at Hindi films, failed, and was now looking for a break in the family business of politics. ‘Modi is winning the elections,’ Chirag told his father. ‘Let’s just join the right side this time.’ When I interviewed Paswan for a programme, it was his son who did all the talking. The pro-Modi generation gap was showing here as well!

Getting Paswan on board suited the RSS too. Part of the Sangh’s strategy was to woo as many Dalit leaders as possible to their side—Udit Raj in Delhi, Ramdas Athawale in Maharashtra were all brought on board. ‘We wanted to create a sense of a pan-Hindu identity without saying so openly,’ admits a BJP strategist.

More allies quickly followed. From Maharashtra came an important farmer leader, Raju Shetty. Just weeks earlier, Shetty had come to see me and said he had an offer to join the AAP. I later asked him why he had switched to the Modi camp. ‘In rural Maharashtra, there is no AAP. The only person the rural youth want to listen to is Modi!’ he said. The deal was stitched by the Maharashtra BJP leader Gopinath Munde.